comprise 7.95 per cent of Bangladesh's 165.1 million population, making them the largest minority in the Muslim-majority state. They faced frequent attacks even during the Hasina regime. "Hindu atrocities under Hasina's regime were never highlighted," argues Shafiqul Alam, press advisor to Yunus. "But even if a few incidents happen now, they are being projected exponentially. This shouldn't be the case."

INDIA'S NEWEST HEADACHE

The violent reprisals against Hindus in Bangladesh are an outcome of the complex interplay of political and communal tensions that afflict the country. There may be some truth to the Yunus government's claim that these attacks are politically motivated, but it has done little so far to address the systemic vulnerability of minorities who continue to bear the brunt of violent outbursts. Worse, graffiti calling for complete non-cooperation with India and demanding a Bangladesh government "free from the clutches of Delhi" has appeared on many Dhaka streets. Indian foreign secretary Vikram Misri's visit to Dhaka on December 9, during which he also met Yunus, was intended to help tamp down on the rising anti-India rhetoric and ensure the safety of minorities while emphasising that India looked forward to "moving the relationship in a positive, forward-looking and constructive direction".

HASINA'S OUSTER, THE ATTACKS AGAINST HINDUS AND THE RISING RADICALISM ENGULFING BANGLADESH ARE OF HUGE CONCERN TO INDIA

For India, the ouster of Hasina, the attacks against the Hindu minorities, the anti-India sentiment and the rising radicalism threatening to engulf Bangladesh are matters of huge concern and worry. Situated at the mouth of the Bay of Bengal, Bangladesh straddles a crucial geographical space contiguous to India's sensitive northeastern states. Ever since India supported the Mukti Bahini in the 1971 war of independence and helped Bangladesh break away from Pakistan, relations between the two countries have been on a roller-coaster—on the up whenever Hasina, daughter of the nation's founding father, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, who was assassinated in an army coup in August 1975, was in power and plummeting during the interregnum regimes. During Hasina's two stints in power, first between 1996 and 2001, and then for 15 years from 2009 onward up to her ouster, India's relations with Bangladesh were generally friendly.

When she won a fifth term in January 2024, her Awami League securing a landslide victory in the general election, it was widely criticised as having been rigged in her favour. Her main rival, the Begum Khaleda Zia-headed BNP, had boycotted the election. Her other main rival, the religion-based Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami party, Hasina had barred from contesting elections from 2013 onward. Four days before she fled, she had also banned the group for being an "anti-secular, militant and terrorist" organisation. Bangladeshi Opposition parties blamed India for propping her up despite serious democratic and human rights violations by her government.

After the election, Hasina targeted the BNP and the Jamaat for whipping up student protests over the issue of reserving seats for freedom-fighters' descendants. Despite Hasina agreeing to rescind the reservations, her government's brutal clampdown on agitators, leaving over 2,100 dead in police firing,



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GROUND REPORT

MONK IN THE EYE OF A STORM

How Vaishnav monk Chinmoy Krishna Das has emerged as the face of the protest against attacks on minorities in Bangladesh

By **ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR** *in Chattogram*

Chinmoy Krishna Das was something of a child prodigy. He started preaching religious sermons at the age of 6–7, and earned an audience among local Hindus with his oratorical skills. Born Chandan Kumar Dhar in the Satkania Upazila of Chattogram district, Das was the youngest of four children. Around